

**An Illustration of How the University of Kansas Work Group
Documentation System for Community Initiatives and Other Evaluation Tools
Can Be Used to Evaluate the Tutor/Mentor Connection**

June 2000

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Information presented here was adapted from the KU Work Group studies, concepts and working papers. For more information from the KU Work Group, please call (785) 864-0533 or visit <http://ctb.ukans.edu>. Please do not duplicate or distribute this presentation without permission.

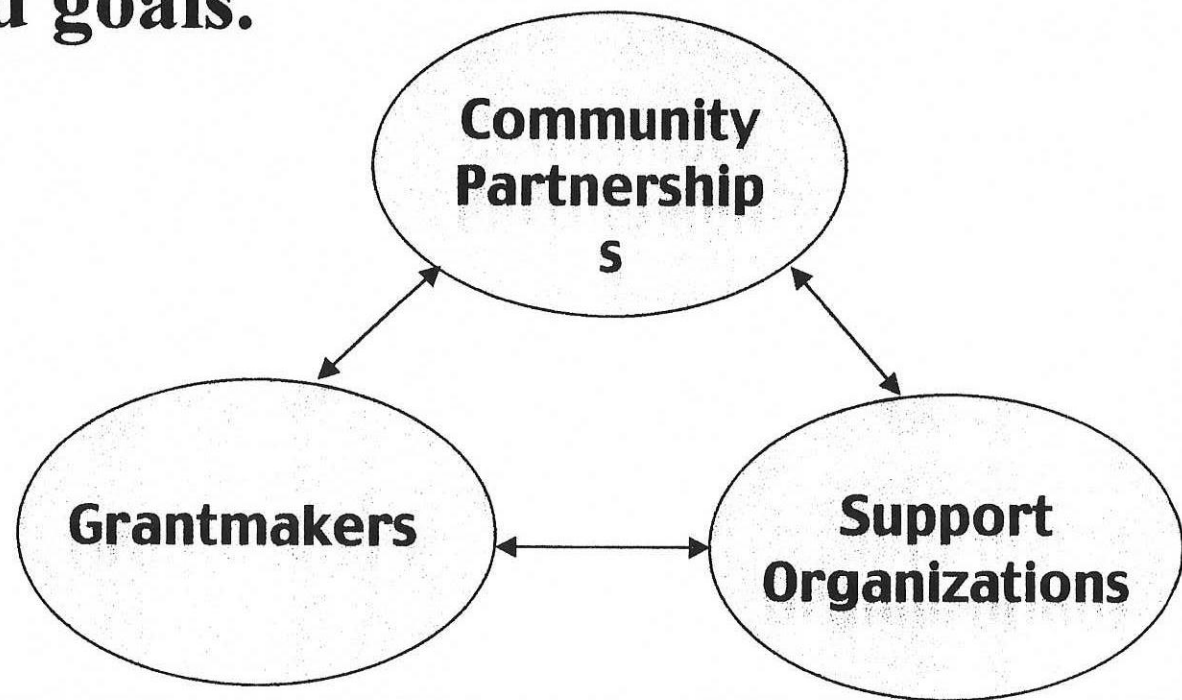
Some Key Points About the Evaluation System

- **Intended to help staff and stakeholders of community initiatives better understand and improve their ability to influence outcomes that matter to their community**
- **Participatory**
- **Offers developmental understanding rather than summative judgment**
- **Focuses on ‘community change’ as an intermediate marker of an initiative’s progress toward its long-term community-level outcomes**

For T/MC, this means

- **The evaluation system will be responsive to providing information that T/MC and its stakeholders can use to make decisions and take actions meaningful to their community.**
- **T/MC staff and stakeholders will participate in decisions for what to evaluate and how to use the evaluation results.**
- **Measurement will track how T/MC works with individuals and groups in the community to create new or modify existing programs, practices, and policies (“community changes”) to enhance the infrastructure for successful tutoring/mentoring.**
- **Data on community change will be used to understand and improve daily progress toward long-term improvements.**

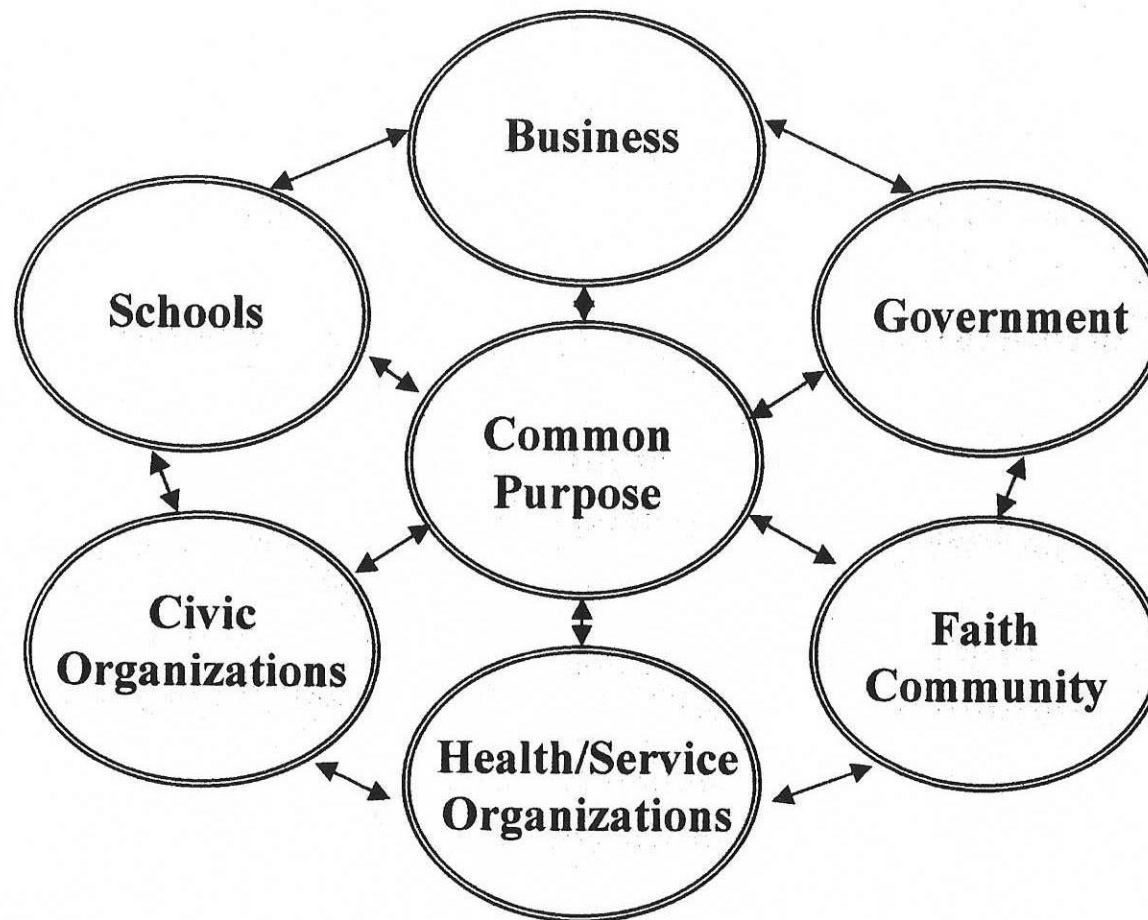
This system is often used in the context of a broad collaborative partnership in which community initiatives, their grantmakers, and support organizations such as research teams work together to understand and improve shared goals.



Some Challenges in the Evaluation of Community Initiatives

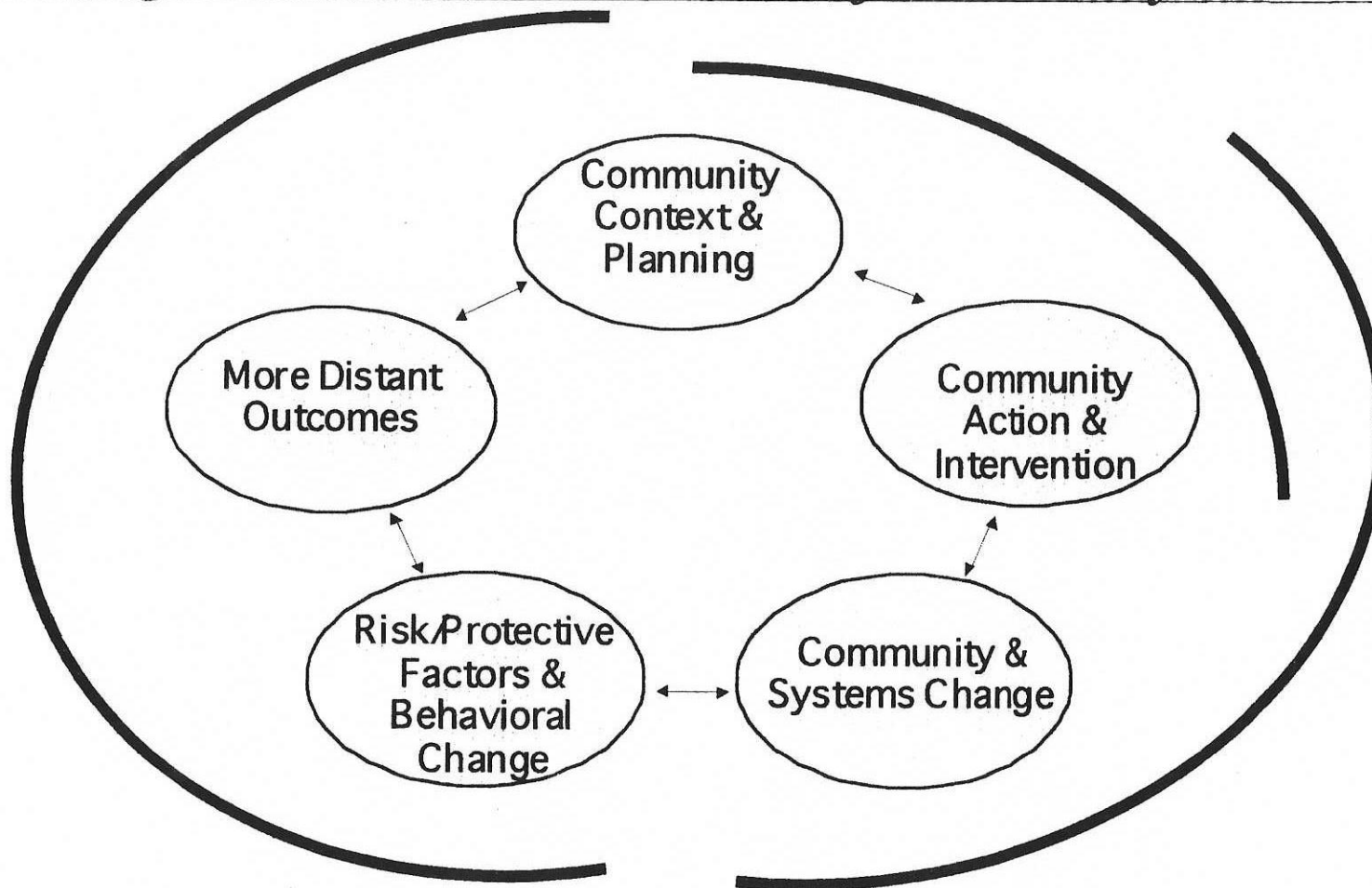
- **Complexity** → **Multiple interventions by multiple implementers in multiple settings**
- **Delayed outcomes** → **5 to 10 years to begin seeing changes in trends of population-level indicators**
- **Inadequate indicators** → **Population-level indicators are often inaccurate, inappropriate, and/or unavailable at the level of analysis targeted by local initiatives**
- **Estimating the “dose”** → **Difficult to keep track of who was exposed to what, when and for how long**
- **Attributing cause and effect** → **Unit of analysis = community; small sample sizes, poor comparison groups & no randomization**
- **Evolving and adaptive nature** → **Actions and “proven” interventions change to fit local context & time**

These challenges often limit programs' and grantmakers' efforts for useful evaluation. These are among the challenges earlier evaluations of T/MC were not able to address and therefore offered limited information to help T/MC understand and improve its progress and outcomes. The proposed evaluation system attempts to provide useful measurement and contribute toward meaningful results in spite of these challenges.



Multi-sector collaboration is natural for initiatives such as T/MC as well as most successful tutor/mentor programs – where success depends on support and work with individuals and organizations throughout the community. While each program may have one or more unique purpose (e.g., reading improvement, job skills training, after-school sports activities) and thus different target outcome (e.g., reading ability, job attainment, physical fitness and prevention of youth violence), all programs share a broader common purpose -- to help raise youth into productive, caring adults. The evaluation system is designed to systematically capture this collaborative process for the fulfillment of this common purpose.

The Evaluation System:
Matching Evaluation with the Work of Community Initiatives

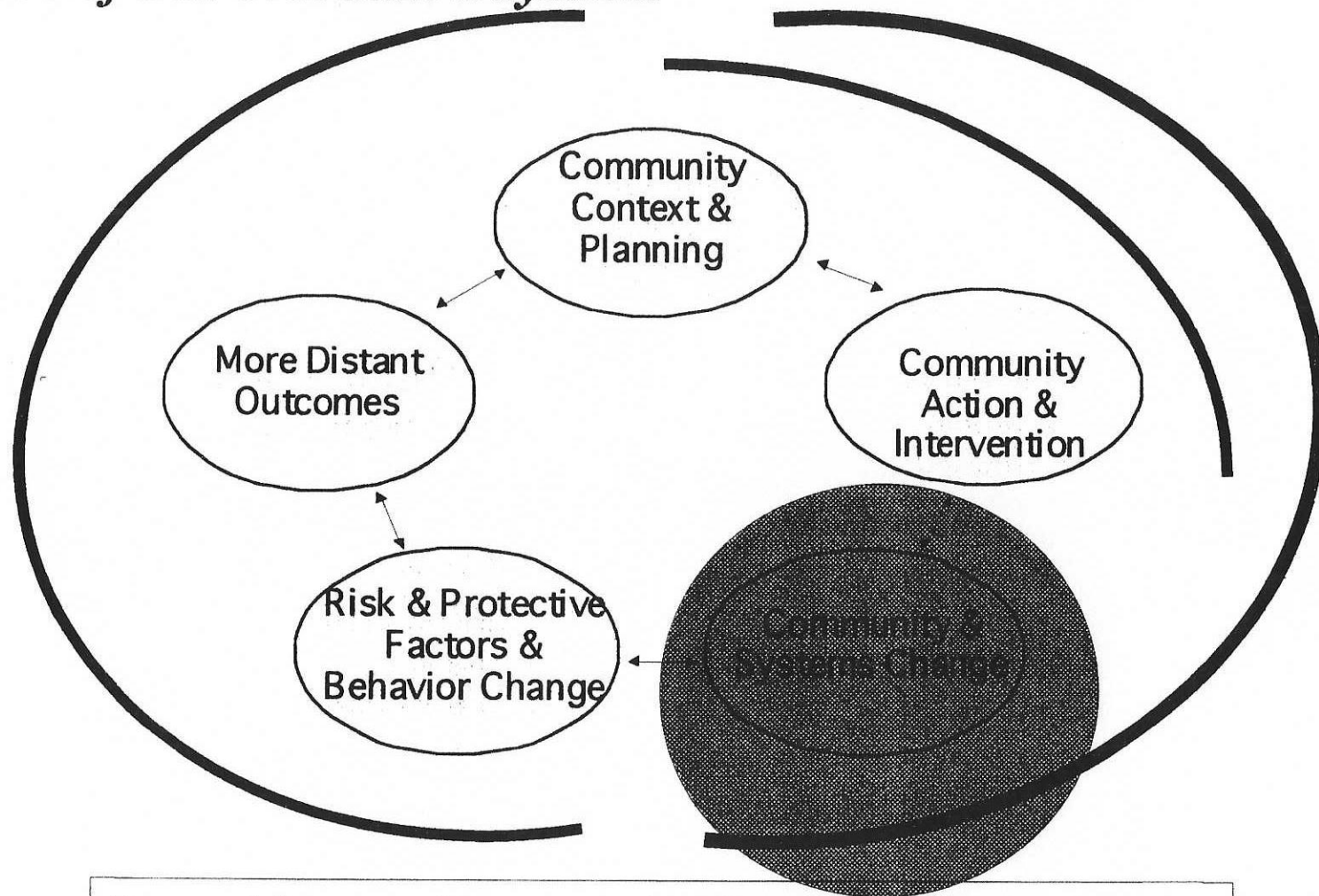


— Process Measures: Documentation System, Satisfaction Surveys

— Intermediate Outcome Measures: Documentation System, Survey of Outcomes

— Distal Outcome Measures: Behavioral Surveys, Community-level Indicators

The Documentation System and its “Community Change” metric are at the core of this evaluation system.



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— Intermediate Outcome Measures: Documentation System, Survey of Outcomes

— Distal Outcome Measures: Behavioral Surveys, Community-level Indicators

The system is designed to inform these core evaluation questions:

- 1. How is the initiative achieving its mission and objectives?**
- 2. Is the initiative serving as a catalyst for change?**
- 3. How is the initiative distributing its efforts?**
- 4. Is the initiative making a difference?**
- 5. What factors contribute to the initiative's effectiveness as a catalyst for change?**

These questions will be adapted to best fit the context of T/MC

Documentation System Components

- 1. T/MC staff complete event logs and forms to collect information (web &/or paper format).**
 - Evaluator and T/MC staff clarify data entered.**
 - Events are “coded” with specific definitions**
 - Coding is assessed for reliability.**
 - Data are summarized, analyzed & graphed.**
 - Results & feedback are shared with relevant audiences.**

Each day or at the end of each week, T/MC staff look through their calendar or day planner and select the events that were important to fulfilling the T/MC mission. This may include important meetings, telephone calls, networking occasions, planned or chance events. This usually excludes daily tasks or general activities. For each event, T/MC staff describe:

- 1. Date the event occurred.**
- 2. Description of the event and its importance to fulfilling T/MC objectives.**
- 3. Whether the event was new or occurred for the first time, or if it was an event modified in some important way.**
- 4. The names of people and organizations within and outside the initiative that helped create the event.**

Some additional type of information for each event will be collected based on what is important to the initiative and key stakeholders (e.g., what objective did the event target, number of participants if the event was a service).

Each event is then given one of the following codes from the Documentation System

EXTERNAL EVENTS (Happens outside the initiative)

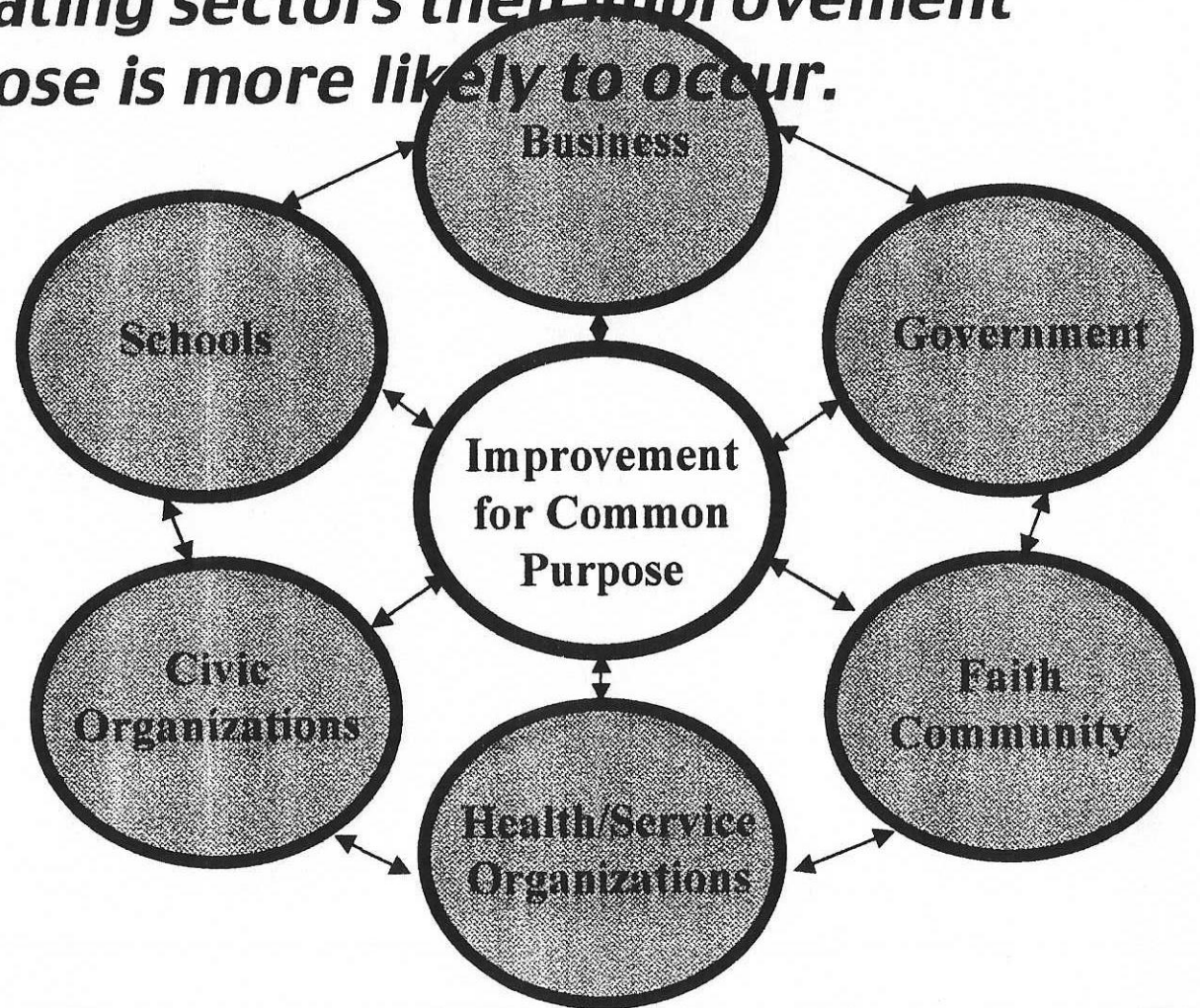
CODE	DEFINITION	EXAMPLES
CA Community Actions	Actions taken in the community to bring about a new or modified program, policy, or practice	*Letters *Phone calls *Town Meetings
CC Community Changes	New or modified programs, policies, or practices in the community facilitated by the initiative that reduces risks for a problem targeted by the initiative	*A new (or modified) program (e.g., mentoring program) *A new (or modified) policy (e.g., labeling low-fat foods) *A new (or modified) practice (e.g., regarding hours of service, or new collaboration)
SP Service Provided	Events that are designed to provide information, instruction, or develop skills of people in the community	*Classes *Workshops *Communications such as bill stuffers
M Media Coverage	Coverage of the initiative or its projects in the newspaper, radio or television, or newsletter	*Radio *TV (e.g., PSA's) *Brochure
X Other	Items for which no code or definition has been created	*Phone calls to set up meetings *Internal staff meetings

INTERNAL EVENTS (Happens within the initiative)

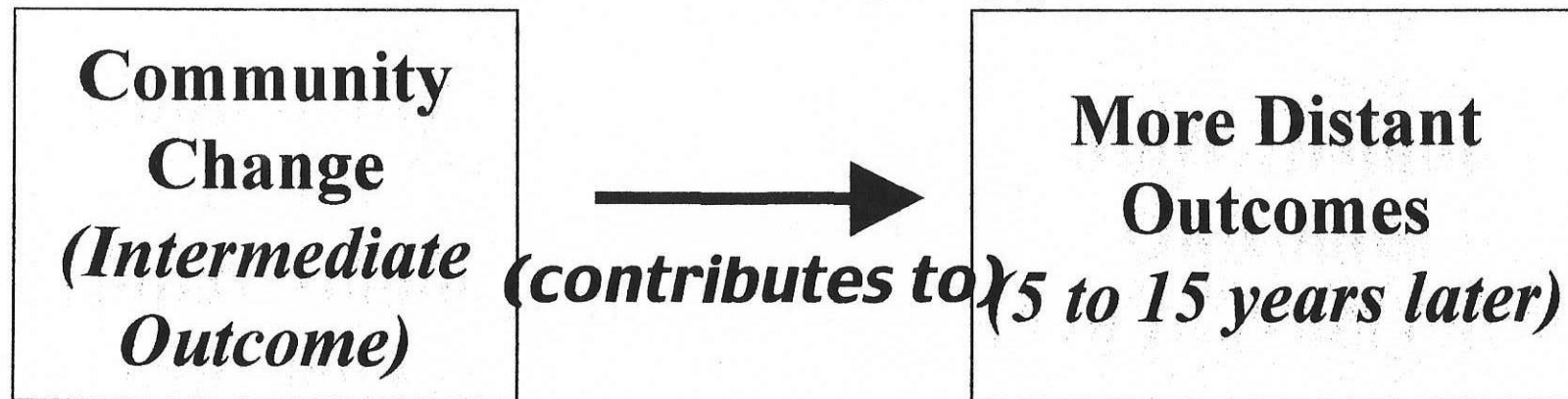
PP Planning Products	Results, or products of planning activities within the group	*Statements of objectives, or action plans developed *Formation of committees or task forces *Hiring new staff
RG Resources Generated	Acquisition of funding for the initiative through grants, donations or gifts in kind	*Materials received *People's professional time *Money *Grants

How is Community defined - e.g. recipients or potential recipients of service
other than programs
all of these

While many types of events contribute to community improvement, the assertion here is that if community change (new or modified programs, practices, and policies related to the mission) occurs throughout the various collaborating sectors then improvement in the common purpose is more likely to occur.



***The data from the evaluation system helps
to test this working hypothesis:***



Distant outcomes are more likely with:

- Increasing amount of change
- Changes of greater intensity of strategy
- Changes with greater durability
- Changes that reach more people or with greater community exposure

In summary, T/MC will track how it is working with the community to improve the infrastructure for successful tutoring/mentoring. This will include tracking various information, but at the core we will track new or modified programs, practices, and policies related to this mission. We will analyze community change facilitated by T/MC in several different ways (including, but not limited to amount, duration, intensity, community exposure) to understand and improve how T/MC can better progress in its mission.

The following slides show some different ways of looking at community change results and their implications. The data used in these slides

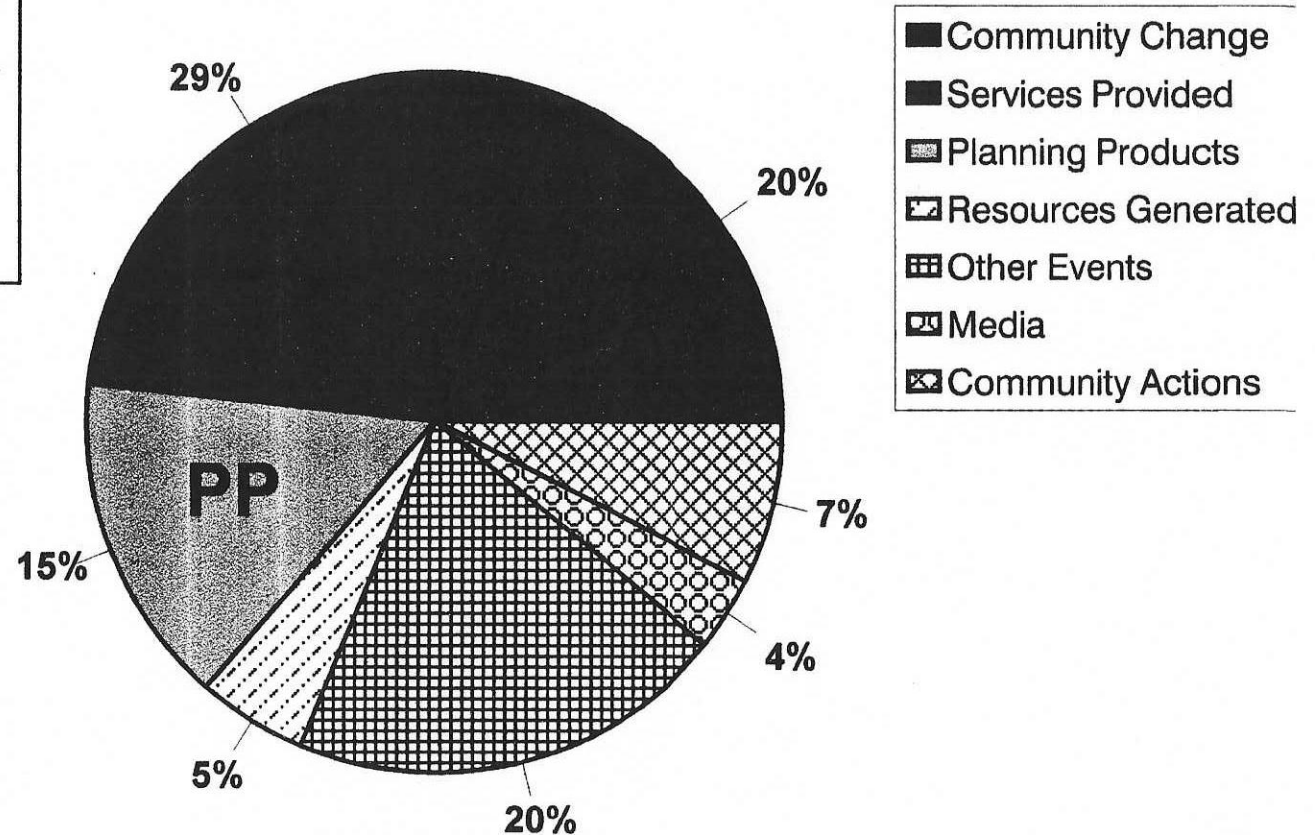
Community Changes

- *new and/or improved tutor/mentor programs*
- *business policies to support recruitment campaign or employee volunteerism*

Services Provided

- *presentations to raise awareness of T/MC*
- *workshops for community groups*
- *community conferences and presentations*

Events Facilitated by T/MC (N=542)



Planning Products

- *hiring T/MC staff & T/MC team development*
- *setting objectives & T/MC organizational development*

How is T/MC changing community conditions to engage more caring adults with youth?

Examples of Community Change. . .

Programs

8 new schools began after-school tutor/mentor services in past month.

Practices

Nations Bank began conducting their own on-site recruitment campaign for area tutor/mentor programs.

4 school districts began publicizing after-school tutor/mentor program opportunities to volunteers of school-time programs.

Policies

Chicago Utilities employees were allowed flex-time for volunteering as tutor/mentors.

One school district adopted policy that all after-school tutor/mentor programs will receive free snacks.

Annual Constituent Survey of Community Changes Facilitated by the T/MC

How important do you believe each community change is for improving the community infrastructure for successful tutoring/mentoring?

	Low	High
1. 10/94 Began comprehensive tutor/mentor training in high schools programs.	1 2 3 4 5	
2. 1/95 Began use of work incentives to promote after-school tutor/mentors.	1 2 3 4 5	
3. 4/95 Began new web-based system for program evaluation.	1 2 3 4 5	

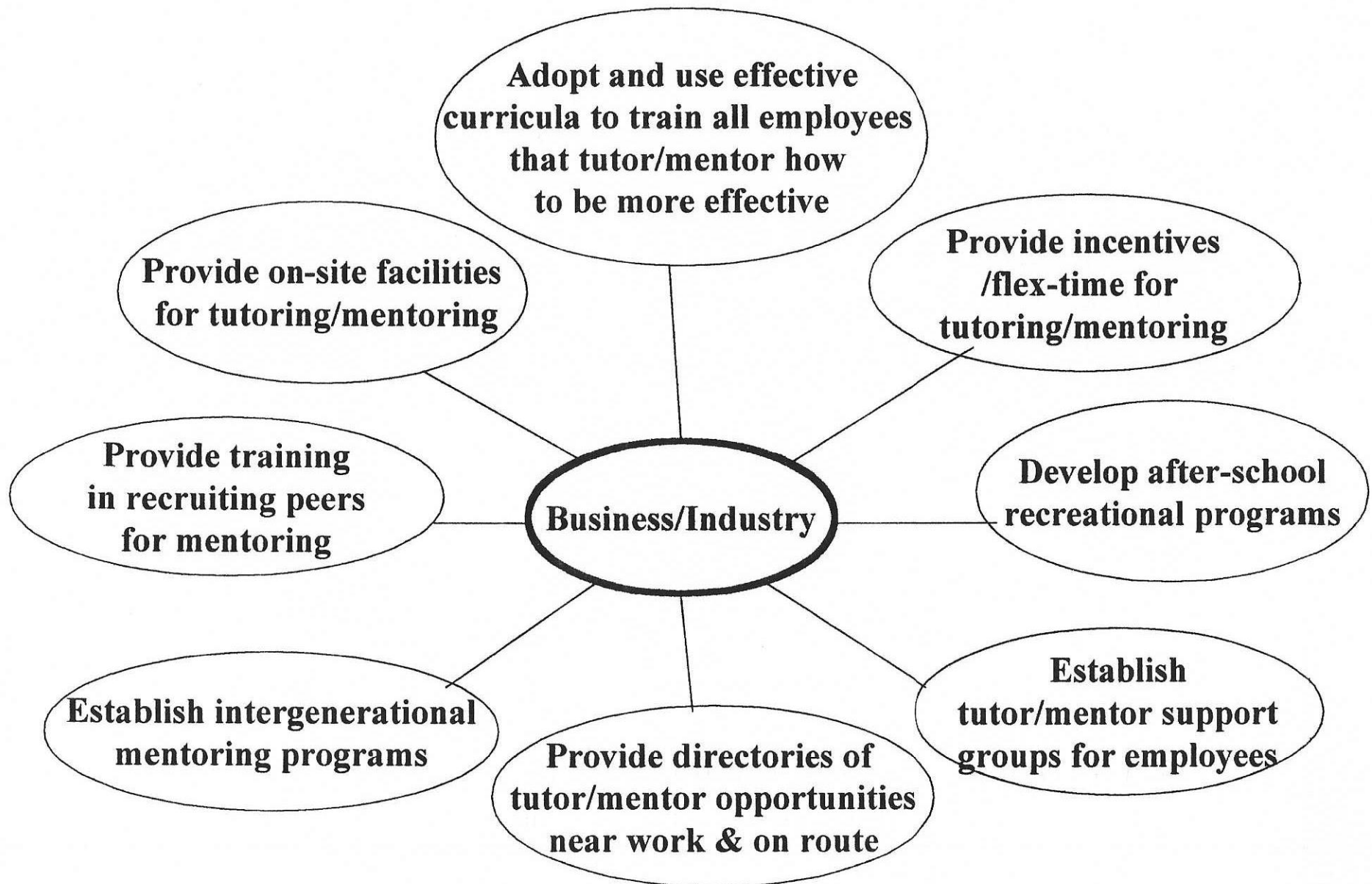
etc....

• Is
di
**Community
Change**

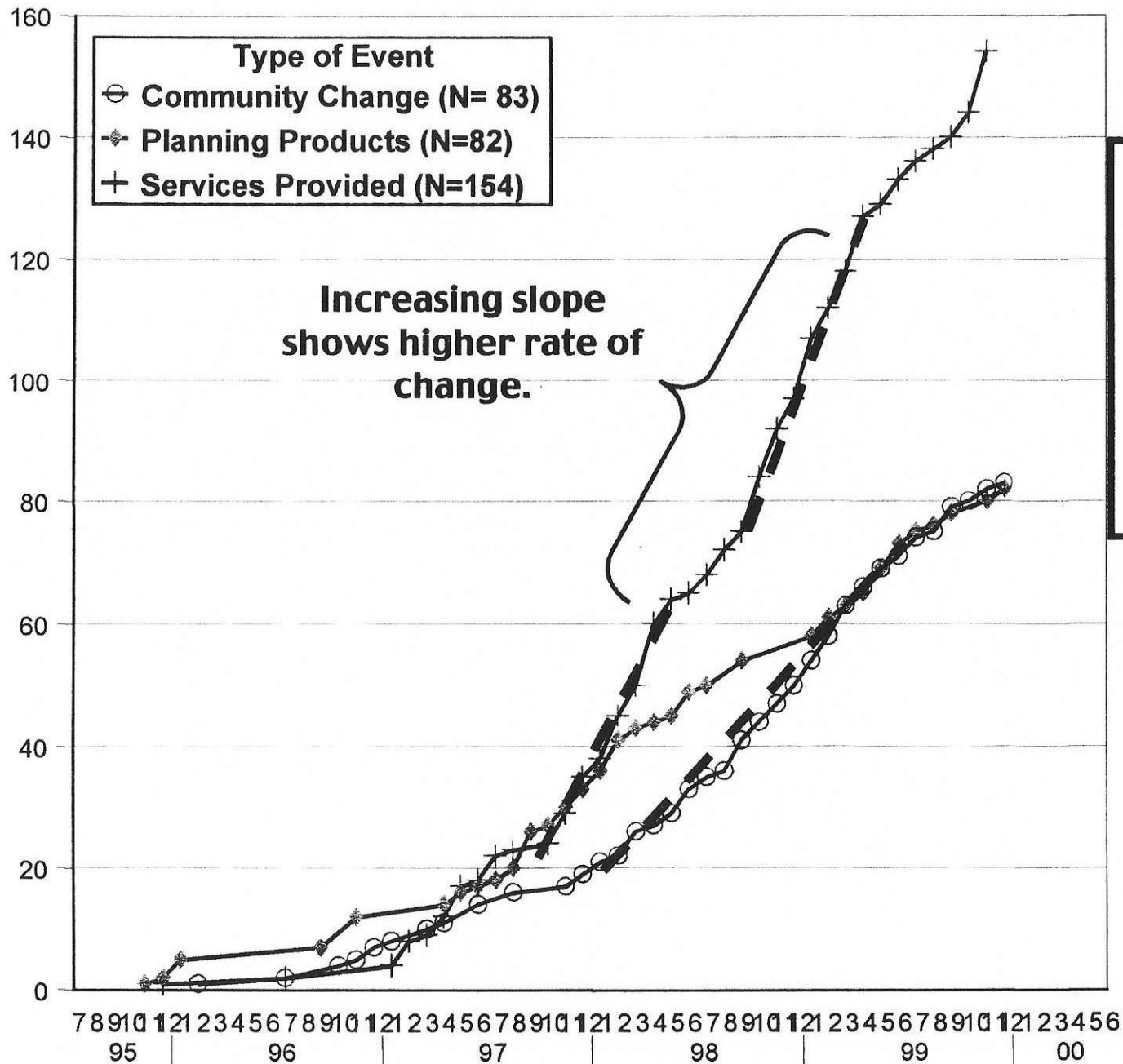
Average Score

	Experts in adolescent development and public health	Local community leaders
1.	5	4
2.	4	2

***Illustrative Community Changes
Facilitated by T/MC: Sector Target = Business/Industry***

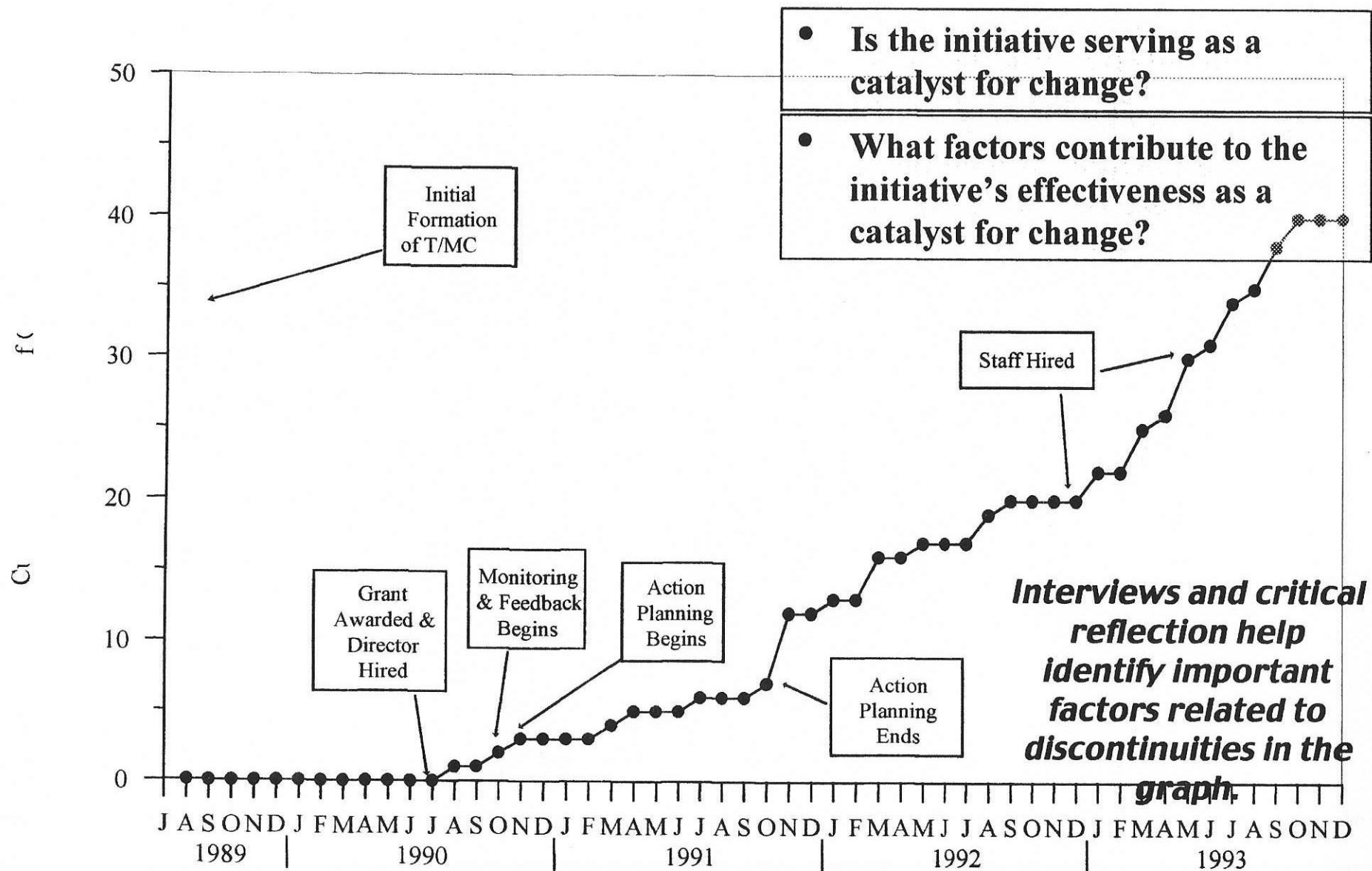


Cumulative Number of Events Facilitated by T/MC

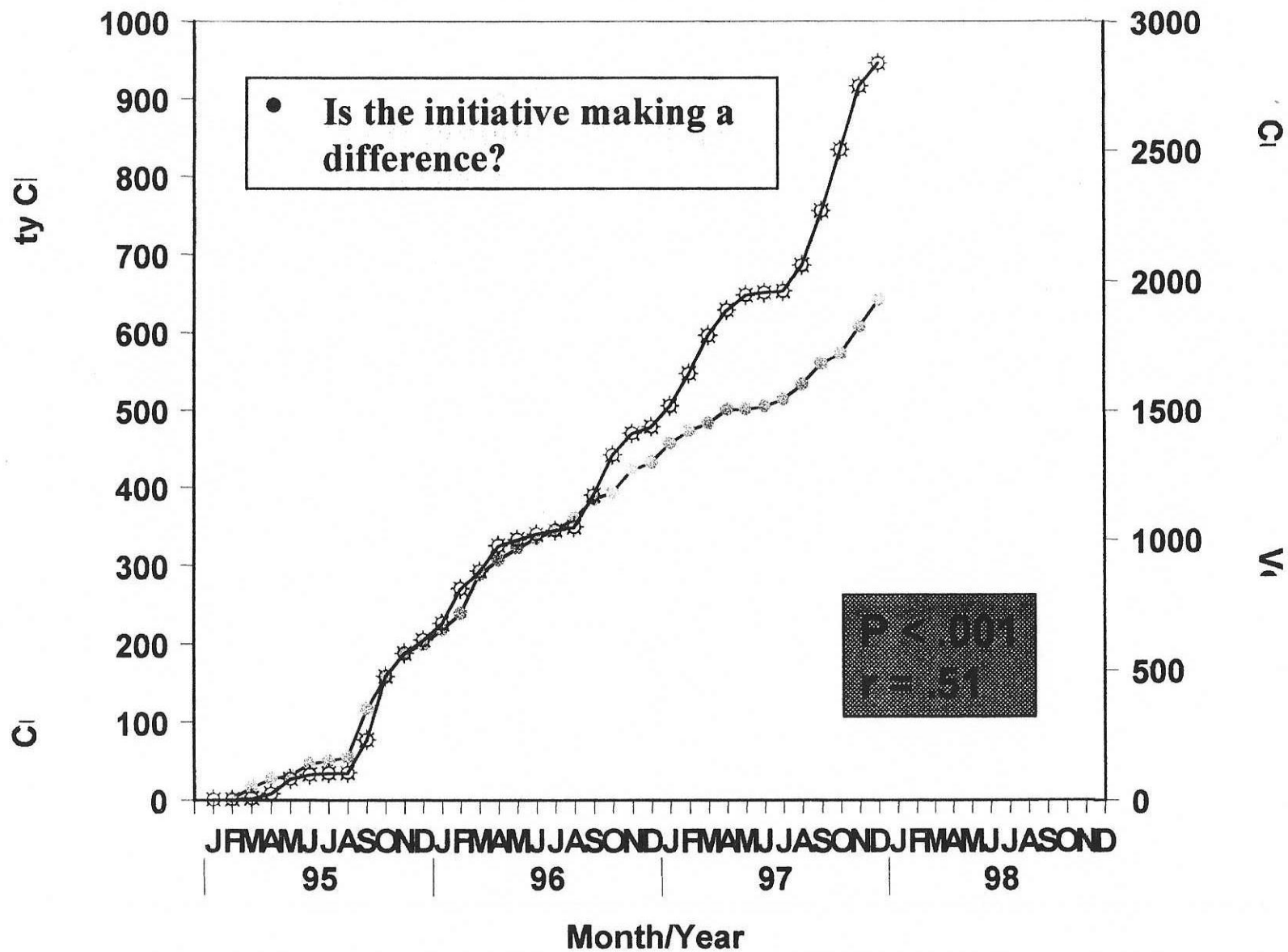


How is the initiative serving as a catalyst for community change?

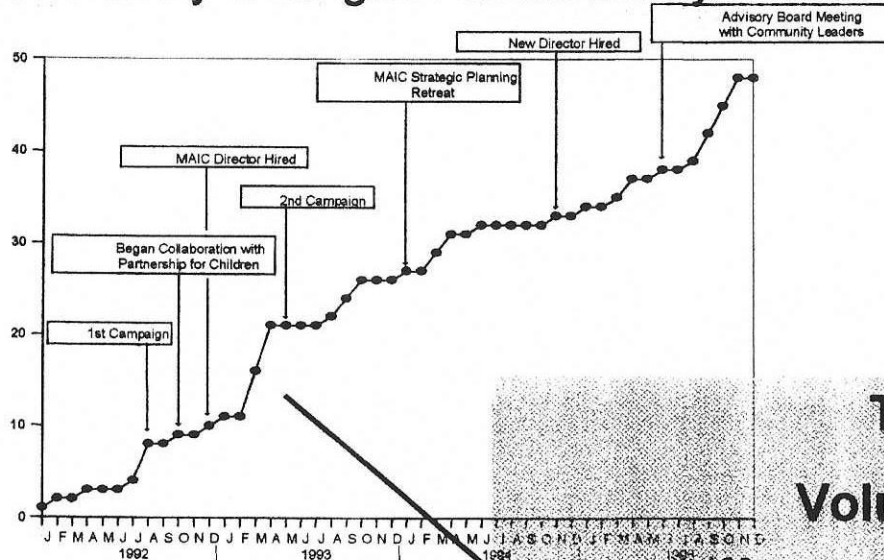
Community Changes Facilitated by T/MC



Community Change & New Volunteers Recruited



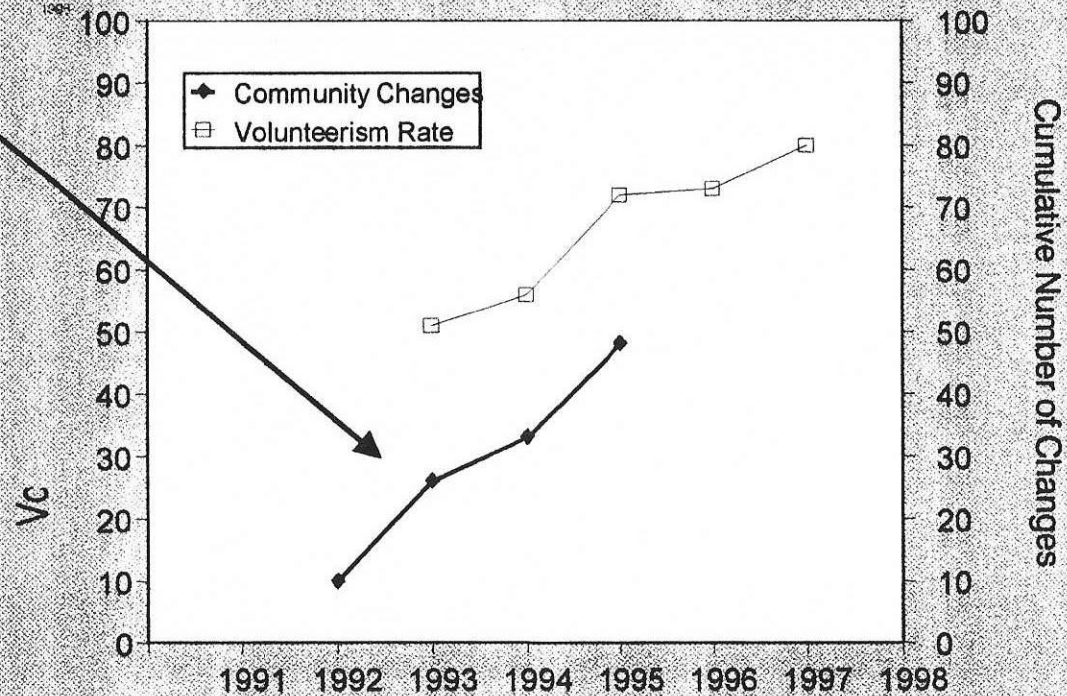
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- **Is the initiative making a difference?**

Tutor/Mentoring In Chicago

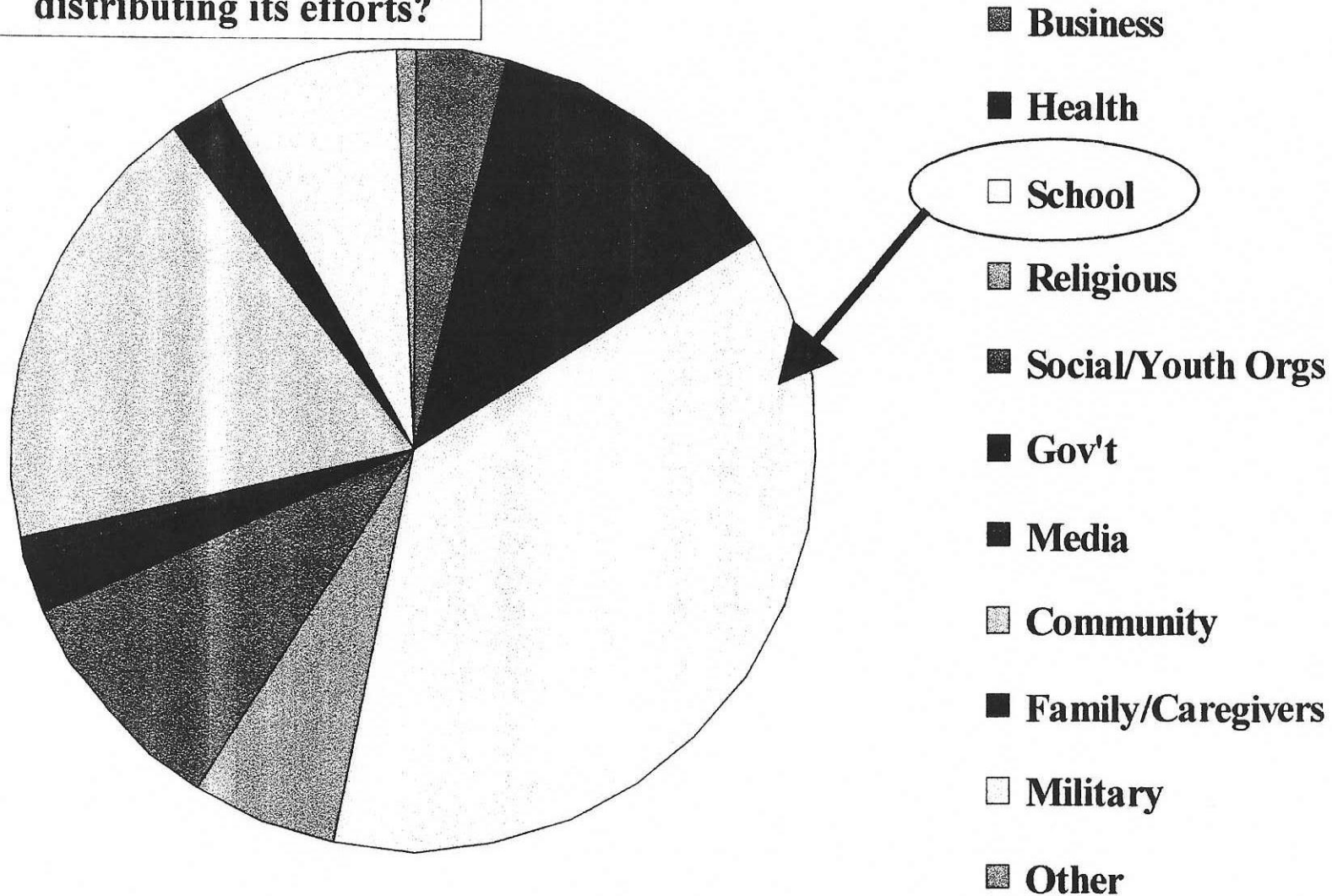
Volunteerism Rates 1991 - 1998



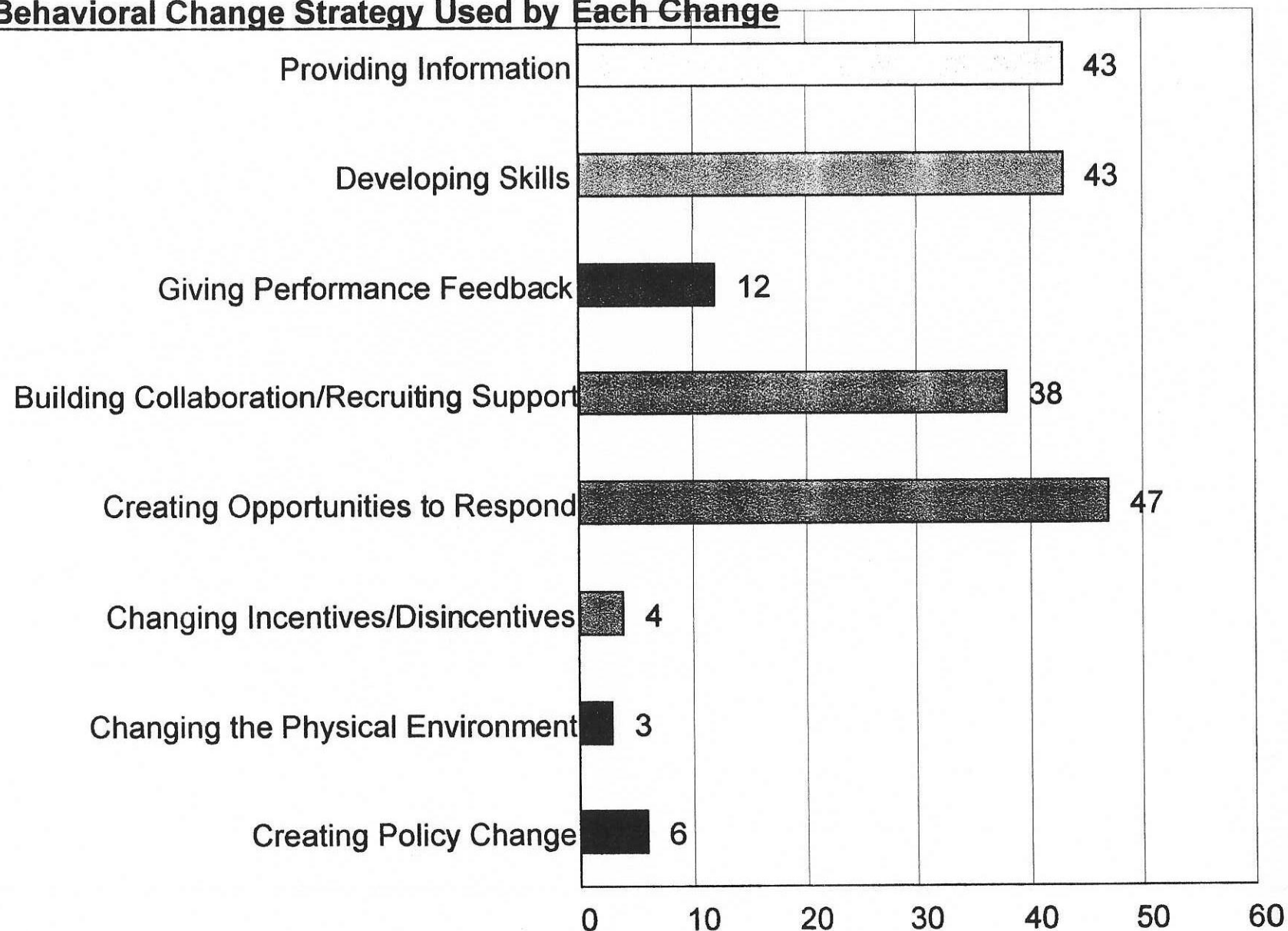
T/MC Community Changes by Sector

N = 150

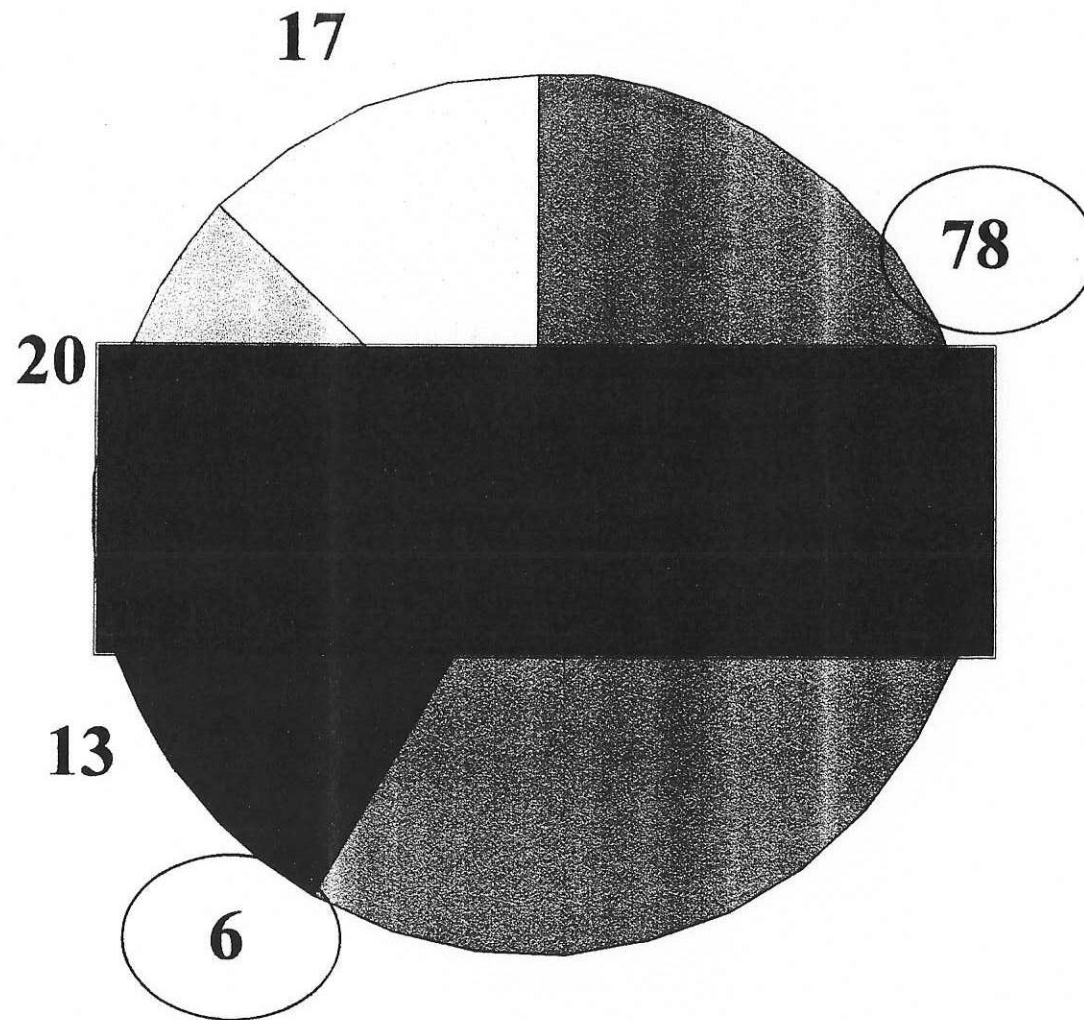
- How is the initiative distributing its efforts?



**Community Changes Shown Across the Different Types of
Behavioral Change Strategy Used by Each Change**



Number of Community Changes by T/MC Target Areas (*by Zip Code*)



Target Area A

Target Area B

Target Areas A & B

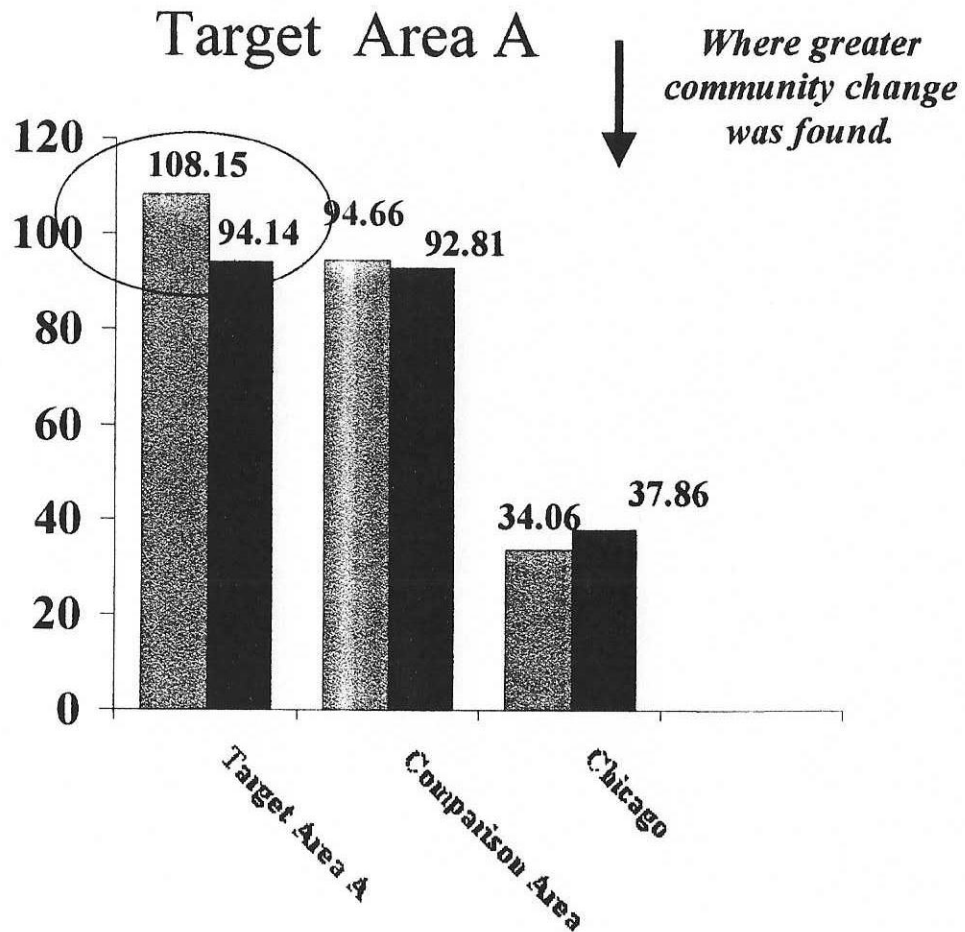
Other Zip Codes

Not located in target zip codes but may reach target population

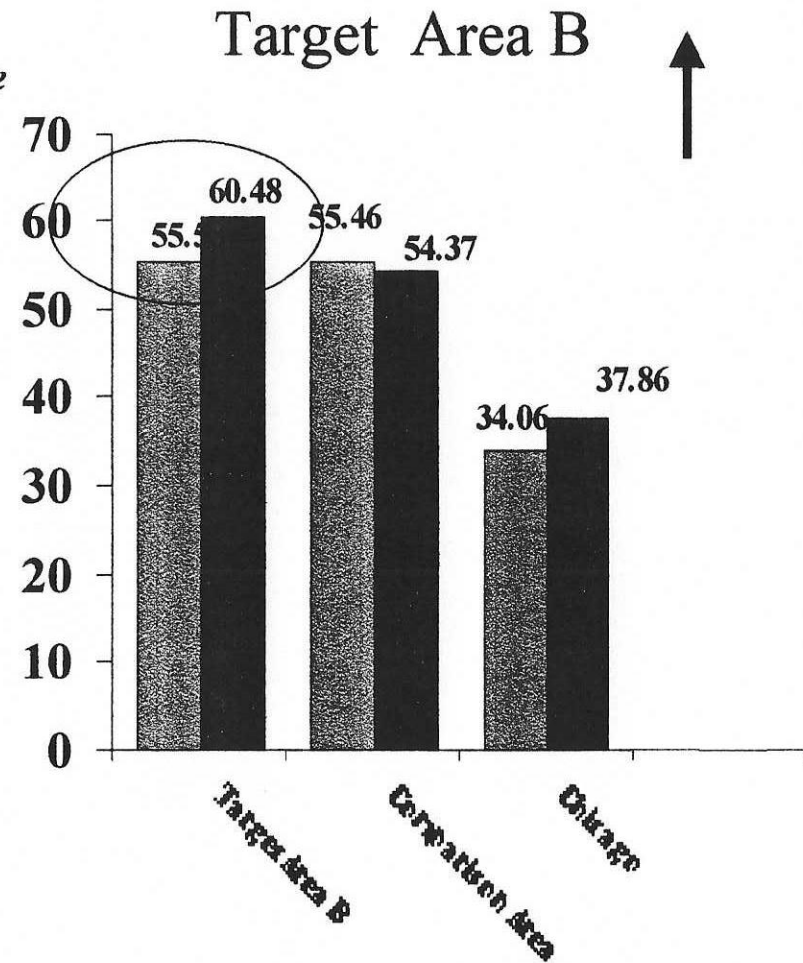
Multiple Zip Codes

Includes Target Areas A & B, and other areas.

High School Drop-Out Rate for T/MC Target Areas A and B



■ Before T/MC Action
■ During T/MC Action



■ Before T/MC Action
■ During T/MC Action

SOME BENEFITS OF THE DOCUMENTATION SYSTEM

<i>For Practice</i>	<i>For Research</i>
Community initiative staff learn to distinguish and share accomplishments and challenges	Systematic and replicable procedures
Understanding of initiative's history - where been and how got here	Verification of intervention implementation
Staff and stakeholders understand progress, barriers and areas for improvement	Source for intervention research
Opportunity to identify best practices and learn from researchers	Opportunity to learn from and demonstrate utility to community
Improved accountability to partners and community	Intermediate marker to assess potential influence of community initiatives on distant community-level outcomes
Intermediate marker to guide current action and track contributions to distant community-level outcomes	

***Today with a myriad of
instruments we can
explore things we never
imagined. But we no
longer see directly what is
right in front of us.***